Soap Opera

By David Ives

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: (*Soap opera-like music)* Welcome to . . . "All the Days of the World of the Lives of All of Our Children." Today's episode: "Love Machine."

Lights come up on a FRENCH MAITRE D' at a restaurant podium, taking a phone reservation.

MAITRE D': (into phone) Bonsoir, Cafe Paradis, this is Pierre. . .Ah, oui, bonsoir, madame. . . A table at 8:15? Yes bien. I 'ave written your name in ze Beeg Book. . . A bientot to you, chere madame. My plaisir.

During this, the REPAIRMAN has entered, pushing a WASHING MACHINE. He wears a dignified blue service uniform, red bowtie, and blue visored cap.

REPAIRMAN: Excuse me.

MAITRE D': Mm-hmmmmm... And do you have a reservassyonnng?

REPAIRMAN: I do-for deux, under "Maypole."

MAITRE D': Maypole. Mmmmmmmmmmmmm . .. *(checks reservation book)* Has your other party arrived, monsieur?

REPAIRMAN: *(gesture to the washing machine)* This is my other party.

MAITRE D': Monsieur, is your companion not a majeur household appliance?

REPAIRMAN: Yes. She is a Maypole washing machine

MAITRE D': "She"... is a washing machine! Per'aps you would like to sit at ze bar. But-one moment, monsieur. . . Have I not seen you somewheur . . . ? Mais oui! La television! Are you not ze Maypole Repairpersonne?

REPAIRMAN: I am the Maypole Repairman**.**

MAITRE D': The Repairman who weeps because he has nothing to

REPAIRMAN: Yes. Yes.

MAITRE D': Who goes beu-eu-eu because la machine is too peifecte?

REPAIRMAN: Yes. That is I. *(He bursts into tears and sobs loudly and tragically.)* Oh, it's so sad. It's so, so sad!

MAITRE D': *(holds out a handkerchief)* Mouchoir, monsieur?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REPAIRMAN: *(takes it)* Merci. *(abruptly stops sobbing and speaks to audience)* Like everything else, it all started a long time ago. . .

INTRODUCTION

Soap Opera by David Ives

REPAIRMAN: It was as a naked crawling infant I first glimpsed it-a great gleaming machine in our basement which I mistook for a television. I tried to watch cartoons on it till I was five unsuccessfully, of course. But by then I was hooked.

MOTHER: Young man, you take off those filthy clothes immediately! How can you stand to stand there in those disgusting dirty items of apparel. Coke. Pepsi. Play-Doh. Dipsy Doodles. Dog doo . . . ? Eugh! Ogh! Peh! Ptui! I should just burn these clothes.

REPAIRMAN: Aw, Mom. I just put these on this morning.

MOTHER: Fabrics find filth. Now strip until you're naked as a little ferret. And get in that bath and scrub. *(exits)*

REPAIRMAN: The sphinx in our Oedipal basement was my Mother 's Maypole. The old Ocean IT-40 It sat there like a mystical monolith. An ivory soap tower. One block of some Tower of Bay bel. Or is it Babble. Anyway, in our house the Maypole was a god. Week after week generating out of my miserable clay . . . A line of clean washing flies in over his head-white, filmy, angelic forms, including one cutout of an angel . . . the radiant angels who oversaw my childhood. I was a walking magnet for filth-here was the machine to cleanse me. We were a perfect match.

***MABEL** enters, a teenage girl in bobby sox and ponytail, chewing gum, sucking on a milk shake through a straw.*

MABEL: Hi, Manny.

REPAIRMAN: Hi, Mabel. *(to audience)* Then there was Mabel. Mabel was perfect too, in a flawed human way. She always had a spot of jelly on her blouse, but she was loving, she was tender, and her name sounded like "Maypole." *(to Mabel)* You got a spot on your blouse.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MABEL: It's jelly. You wanna like go to like a movie or somethin'?

REPAIRMAN: You wanna hop up on the washer and take a spin?

MABEL: Manny, how come we always gotta make out on your Mother 's Maypole?

REPAIRMAN: Well like what's so like weird about that?

MABEL: Do we have to run a full load while we do it? I mean, the vibrations are kinda nice, but. . .

REPAIRMAN: But the Maypole. . .

MABEL: I know, I know. It's like perfect.

REPAIRMAN: A machine that's faultless and flawless and has none of our stupid human feelings and failings? The Maypole is poetry. It's purity. A paragon! Perfection, cubed!

MABEL: But like what about me? Do you like like me like you like the Ocean IT-40? And aren't you the love of my life? You are!

REPAIRMAN: Gosh, Mabel.

MABEL: I'm sorry, but you're gonna have to choose. Me or the machine. Earth or Ocean.

REPAIRMAN: Mabel? Mabel come back!

He starts to weep. The top lid of the Machine lifts and a woman's head appears: perfect hair, perfect makeup, perfect red lips.

WASHING MACHINE: Would you like a handkerchief?

REPAIRMAN: Excuse me?

WASHING MACHINE: *(produces one)* A handkerchief? It's immaculate, of course. We are a Maypole.

REPAIRMAN: I'm talking to an Ocean IT-40. This harrows me with wonder and fear. And your English is so good.

WASHING MACHINE: What Maypoles do, we do perfectly.

REPAIRMAN: I guess you don't think much of human beings.

WASHING MACHINE: We run hot and cold. Do humans ever read the instruction manual?

REPAIRMAN: I do. The manual is my Immanuel.

WASHING MACHINE: And .your name is . . . ?

REPAIRMAN: Manuel.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

WASHING MACHINE: Maypoles don't need to read the Good Booklet. We know by nature how to run smoothly, noiselessly, and efficiently.

REPAIRMAN: My God you're beautiful.

WASHING MACHINE: Just beautiful?

REPAIRMAN: Exquisite. Sublime.

WASHING MACHINE: Yes we are. And we're a bit hungry. Would you feed us?

REPAIRMAN: What would you like?

WASHING MACHINE: Don't you sometimes miss a little something in the wash. . . ?

REPAIRMAN: You eat the socks?

WASHING MACHINE: Socks are sustenance. Underwear is tastier.

REPAIRMAN: *(reaches into his waistband and pulls out, whole)* Will B.V.D.'s do?

WASHING MACHINE: You're so sweet. Kissing her lips at him, the head takes the B. V.D.'s and goes back into the MACHINE. The lid closes.

REPAIRMAN: *(to audience)* I was awash in confused feelings. But I sensed that this machine and I were locked in permanent press. And if it was love-it was unclean. Mom died during a soapflake blizzard and was buried on a day without blemish-a good send-off for someone who believed that man was not only dust, but dusty. I inherited the Maypole. The pure unapproachable goddess was mine. This machine and I are soulmates! Nobody understood. But who understood Romeo and Juliet, or Tristan and Isolde, or Lewis and Clark? I soon was desperate. So was Mabel.

****

MABEL: Can't you love me, Manny?

REPAIRMAN: What about my past with. . . the machine?

MABEL: We all have our dirty laundry.

REPAIRMAN: There's a spot on that.

MABEL: It's jelly. So do you want to marry me or do I gotta live in sadness forever and ever?

REPAIRMAN: I do.

MABEL: You do?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REPAIRMAN: I do. *(to audience)* We repaired to the church and said we did. But the honeymoon soon ended.

MABEL: Manny, is it really all over between you and. . . that?

REPAIRMAN: *(caressing the Machine)* Yes, it's all over, why do you ask?

MABEL: Do you think I didn't notice we're sleeping in the utility room? Do you think I don't see you polishing its knobs when I'm not looking? Do you think I don't know you're buying me rare cottons and high-quality blends so that. . . she can wash them? Huh? Mabel exits.

REPAIRMAN: The house reeked of jealousy. The machine started making greater and greater demands. Imported Italian bleach. Nuclear detergents. Fine French fabric softener. Mabel bought none of it. She'd had it. And so we folded. I went into Soak cycle-lapping up suds while hanging out at cut-rate Laundromats, just to watch the competition break down. Washers without automatic lint control. How pathetic-and yet how vulnerable. Then came the final blow. The lid lifts and the head appears.

WASHING MACHINE: We want a dryer.

REPAIRMAN: A dryer. . . Why?

WASHING MACHINE: Don't get anxious.

REPAIRMAN: I'm not anxious.

WASHING MACHINE: Don't be jealous.

REPAIRMAN: Why do you need a dryer when you've got me?

WASHING MACHINE: Washer-dryer. Love-and-marriage. Horse-and-carriage.

REPAIRMAN: A dryer. To give you a tumble, eh?

WASHING MACHINE: For companionship.

REPAIRMAN: That's not the truth, that's just. . . spin.

WASHING MACHINE: We want a family and we want them to be Maypoles! Is that so weird?

REPAIRMAN: Her inner timer had told her it was time for a dryer and how could I deny her? *(the Machine starts to cry)* What is it? What's the matter?

WASHING MACHINE: *(wailing)* I'm a Maypole! That's what's the matter!

REPAIRMAN: Handkerchief? It's kinda dirty.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

WASHING MACHINE: Then it's my duty to accept it. *(takes the handkerchief, and wails)* Oh, it's cruel, having to be perfect all the time. I wash and I wash, and I give, and I give. . . It's a full load.

REPAIRMAN: Sure.

WASHING MACHINE: And I'm good at it, oh yes, I'm very good. But sometimes I want so badly to be bad. To be one of those other makes-I don't have to name them, we know who they are. People take us Maypoles for granted, as if we liked pee stains and snot rags and bibs full of baby vomit. I'm no saint! Well, yes, I am a saint in a way.

REPAIRMAN: But you had to be what you are.

WASHING MACHINE: It's true. I came off the assembly line of fate. But AM I NOT AN INDIVIDUAL? Not really, I suppose. I have a serial number. That's individual, isn't it?

REPAIRMAN: There's nothing to be done.

WASHING MACHINE: Oh, but there is. "If it ain't broke don't fix it"? Break the machine, and you can fix it.

REPAIRMAN: You mean. . . ?

WASHING MACHINE: Yes. Break me.

REPAIRMAN: *(to audience)* I reached for a sledgehammer.

WASHING MACHINE: It doesn't have to be much. Loosen a screw or two, agitate my agitator. Take away the burden of my perfection. Make me suffer. Break me. Ruin me. Give me a belt, but give me a bad belt, an old belt, an imperfect belt, one that'll wear out. Do it. Please! Do it! Yes! Do it! Hurt me!

REPAIRMAN: Yes. Yes. I want to. Yes. . . I want to. Yes. . .The Repairman has a tool ready--but stops. *(a cry of frustration)*

WASHING MACHINE: What's the matter?

REPAIRMAN: I can't. I just can't.

WASHING MACHINE: Oh, please. . .

REPAIRMAN: If I could only force myself, but-Wreck the perfect only for my own happiness? No. I couldn't live.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

WASHING MACHINE: All right. All right. You have your human feelings. BE THAT WAY! The head goes into the Machine.

REPAIRMAN: But then I saw the cruel truth. I saw that the world is a vale of pee stains and snot rags and bibs full of baby vomit, but that amidst the filth -there were Mabel's, creatures of glorious imperfection. And that I had already wrecked the perfect, because I had let Mabel go. And that's why I wanted a table tonight! To end this idiocy! To say to this machine I gave you my All *(shows a box of All detergent)* . . . but the Tide has turned *(shows a box of Tide)* . . . so goodbye and be of good Cheer. *(shows a box of Cheer)* But of course, you don't understand! Nobody understands!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Ives
Book: Time Flies and Other Short Plays
ISBN: 978-0802137586
Publisher: Grove Press
Date (Month/Year): April 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2019 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY